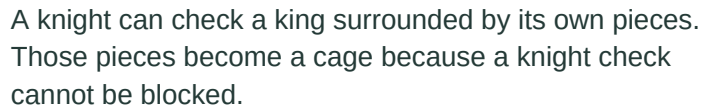


Smothered mates

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES



Trace the knight's route to the checking square and identify the enemy pieces that deny the king its escape squares.

The defending king is on h8. Look for a defender that can be displaced or overloaded.

Previous move: 19...Bxf1. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

20. Qg8+ Rxg8 21. Nf7#

20.Qg8+ Check restricts Black to 1 legal reply here. From g8 it attacks king on h8 and rook on f8. Recorded reply: **20...Rxxg8**.

21.Nf7# Mate: knight on f7 gives check; Black has no legal reply.

The line ends in checkmate against the king on h8. Material gain is unnecessary once no legal defense exists.

Which piece delivers the final check, and why can the defender not continue? **Answer:** Knight on f7. The king is in check and the position has zero legal replies.

A familiar pattern is insufficient if the knight can be captured. Verify protection and every legal king move.